Sri Lanka, I had a warm and loving home to return to. It was no mean feat, especially since this particular unit in the block of four flats had been unoccupied for a long time and was being used as a dumping ground for leftover construction material. Over and above this, she also secured a job for herself in the St Mary's Girls School, teaching French to the secondary classes. Isha was two years old by then and quite a handful at home but extremely shy of strangers. We had put her in a playschool run by a Mrs Pestonji, which Isha enjoyed going to. My routine while studying for the DSSC exam was quite set, though not extreme. There was a fine balance between work (studying) and play (family time). A few hours of study before breakfast, then helping Veena to get Isha ready for her playschool. Once both the girls had left, a few more hours of study till lunchtime. Isha and I would lunch together, and after lunch, I would play with her and tell her some stories till she fell asleep (sometimes I would doze off too). Veena would return in the mid-afternoon and I would study till about 7 p.m. From then on, it was family time, playing with Isha, her dinner, helping her get ready for bed and some more good-night stories. Following a short after-dinner stroll, it was back to the study table, but never beyond midnight. I always felt that it was not the hours spent sitting at the table but the quality of work in those hours that was more important. On Saturday evenings we used to go for the weekly shopping, followed by dinner at the India Coffee House on Moledina Road. Sundays were off days, spent with my parents at Aundh as well as our uncle, Dr AS Parasnis, who had been a professor at IIT Kanpur. Thus refreshed, I was ready to hit the books on Monday mornings.

In the same block of four flats was my coursemate Arwind Kundalkar from India Squadron, who had also taken leave to prepare for the DSSC exam. We often used to study together,

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